and the Shansabani lineage newly established at Ghazna. In fact, both sets of verses came to be integral parts of the architectural decorations of buildings along the Indus's banks during the later 1170s–1180s, buildings constructed in the wake of the eastward campaigns of Mu'izz al-Din and the Ghazna Shansabanis.[49]

The use of these verses within the epigraphic program of the South Palace's Oratory F is significant for at least two reasons: since they came into limited circulation in the eastern Persianate regions – especially Afghanistan – with the architectural patronage of the Firuzkuh Shansabanis as of the 1160s CE, their presence at Lashkari Bazar renders unlikely the earlier date that Sourdel-Thomine suggested, *viz.* following 'Ala' al-Din Husain's violent passing through the region more than twenty years before. Instead, the verses' appearance points to a date *as of* the late 1170s certainly for this part of the South Palace, which would coincide with Mu'izz al-Din's interventions there. But these inscriptions hold additional importance for our purposes: adopting what could have been a group of Qur'anic verses coalescing in the architectural patronage of his older brother, it appears that the newly crowned Shansabani Sultan Mu'izz al-Din also left an intentional architectural mark upon his own hard-won imperial prizes. Indeed, this particular epigraphic association continued into Shansabani-associated architecture throughout the Indus's alluvia, as we shall see in Chapter 6.

A New Imperialism

This chapter's examinations of architectural remains attributable to the Shansabanis at Ghazna, Bust, and Lashkari Bazar enable several observations regarding the emergence of a third Shansabani lineage. Perhaps most tantalizingly, they reveal the new imperial *modus operandi* of the recently crowned Sultan Mu'izz al-Din and the Ghazna Shansabanis. These observations will be extremely important as we examine their expansionist activities farther eastward, initially throughout the plains and valleys intimately associated with the Indus River (Chapter 6), and ultimately in the north Indian *duab* (cf. Volume II).

Upon "zooming out" to a bird's-eye view of Sultan Mu'izz al-Din's establishment of Shansabani rulership over the Yamini–Ghaznavids' core imperial regions, we cannot help but note that, architecturally speaking, Shansabani authority was expressed primarily *via* a marked renovation and reuse of the existing built environment rather than the creation of it *ex novo*: palatial and other complexes were not razed and then erected anew; instead, distinguishable interventions in already present architectural fabrics declared the latter's new Shansabani affiliations. Thus, the commanding courtyard of Ghazna's principal palace received new